The Decline of Empire and the Arrival of Islam

The Gupta Empire saw a series of weak emperors that caused a steady decline. In 550 CE, the Gupta Empire came to a screeching halt. Harshavardhana replaced the Gupta Empire and ruled between 590 and 647 CE. He was a well-educated man who had written three plays in addition to a number of other literary works. He is known as a dedicated Buddhist who encouraged the arts. He opposed the slaughtering of animals but was not averse to killing men on the battlefield. Out of all the battles he fought in his lifetime, he only lost once. As a great military tactician, his reign saw Northern India blossom once more for a short period of time. Both the Gupta Empire and Harshavardhana had stopped foreign invasions during their lifetime. After their demise, the smaller kingdoms fell to squabbling amongst themselves once more.

In 712 CE, Muhammed bin Quasim invaded India and took over what is known as modern day Pakistan. The Muslim armies established a new era and the old native empires came to an end. From this time onwards, India saw a rise of independent city states. Islamic monotheism was established in only some parts of India where many converted to the new religion. The Sultans marched on the northwestern regions and the country experienced a new foreign influence yet again. The Muslims ruled parts of India for several centuries. This continued until the mid-20th century when Portugal, France and Britain came to colonize India.